

GUINEA PIG • CAVIA PORCELLUS

Keep your guinea pigs the right way from day one.

A complete, fact-checked printable manual: the space this species actually needs, the vitamin C rule that makes it different from every other small pet, heat as a genuine emergency, and the health pages that turn a four-year guinea pig into an eight-year one.

INSIDE

- ✓ Enclosure sizing in square feet, and why the pet shop cage is not one
- ✓ Pairing and bonding, step by step, and how to sex a pig properly
- ✓ Vitamin C by body weight, four food charts and the never-feed list
- ✓ Ten health pages, the antibiotic list to hand your vet, and fillable logs

41 pages

Beginner

Print or tablet

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CONTENTS

What's inside

Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

GETTING STARTED

How to Use This Package	3
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SECTION 01 · QUICK PROFILE

Quick Profile & Cost Overview	4
-------------------------------	---

SECTION 02 · FULL CARE GUIDE

Enclosure Size, Shape & Flooring	5
Bedding, Hides & Cage Layout	6
Temperature, Heat Stress & Household Climate	7
Common Mistakes, Enrichment & Floor Time	8
Pairs and Groups: Choosing Your Guinea Pigs	9
Introducing & Bonding Two Guinea Pigs	10
Handling, Sounds & Body Language	11
Hay: the 80% Nobody Budgets For	12
Vitamin C: the Rule That Makes This Species Different	13
Daily Vegetables & Greens	14
Pellets, Fruit, Treats & the Never-Feed List	15
Grooming, Nails, Coats & Boar Cleaning	16
Sexing, Neutering & the Breeding Deadline	17

SECTION 03 · HEALTH & COMMON ISSUES

Health Red Flags & the 8 to 12 Hour Rule	18
GI Stasis, Bloat & a Pig That Stops Eating	19
Dental Disease & Malocclusion	20
Scurvy: Stages, Treatment & Recovery	21
Respiratory Infection & Pneumonia	22
Bladder Stones & Urinary Disease	23
Ovarian Cysts & Reproductive Disease	24
Mites, Lice, Ringworm, Lumps & Bumblefoot	25
Antibiotics & Enterotoxemia	26
Anesthesia & the Vet Conversation	27
Droppings, Weight & Body Condition	28

SECTION 04 · QUICK REFERENCE

Setup Checklist & Targets	29
Emergency & Quick Targets Card	30

SECTION 05 · OWNER TOOLS

Budget & Shopping List	31
First 30 Days Checklist	32
Symptom Quick Reference	33
Daily, Weekly & Seasonal Routine	34
Heat Waves, Power Outages & Travel	35
Pet-Sitter Sheet	36
Owner Log	37
Equipment & Vet Log	38

REFERENCE

Glossary	39
Sources & Further Reading	40
Version History & About	41

START HERE

How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

If you haven't brought any home yet

Read pages 4 through 15 in order before buying anything. Two decisions cost the most to undo: the enclosure on page 5, which nearly everyone buys too small and replaces inside a year, and the number of pigs on page 9, which is not really a preference. Then use the Budget and Shopping List on page 31 and buy once.

If your guinea pigs are already home

Go to page 13 first. Vitamin C is the one requirement this species has that no other common small pet shares, and it is the most common preventable illness in pet guinea pigs. It takes five minutes to fix and weeks to go wrong. Then audit the setup against the checklist on page 29, and if anything looks off at all, page 18, which explains why the safe waiting window here is measured in hours.

Print these first

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ Page 29: Setup Checklist & Targets | ☐ Page 34: Daily, Weekly & Seasonal Routine |
| ☐ Page 30: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 36: Pet-Sitter Sheet |
| ☐ Pages 26 and 27: Antibiotics, Anesthesia & the Vet Conversation | ☐ Page 37: Owner Log |
| ☐ Page 33: Symptom Quick Reference | ☐ Page 28: Droppings, Weight & Body Condition |

WHY THIS PACKAGE EXISTS

A guinea pig is sold as a starter pet and priced like one, and almost every part of that framing is wrong. It needs more floor space than a rabbit hutch provides, a companion of its own species, a daily fresh vitamin C source, a room that stays cool, and an exotics vet who knows which antibiotics are dangerous to it. Every figure here is cross-checked against veterinary sources, listed on page 40, and every temperature and dimension is given in both imperial and metric.

NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

A cavy-savvy exotics veterinarian. This is a husbandry reference for day-to-day care. Anything urgent is a professional call, not a page in this book, and the window for urgency in this species is short: a guinea pig that has stopped eating is on a clock measured in hours. Find a vet before you need one and write the number on page 30.

SECTION 01

Quick profile

Everything at a glance before you read the detail.

Scientific name	<i>Cavia porcellus</i> . A cavy, and a rodent. Not a pig, and not from Guinea
Origin	Fully domesticated from Andean wild cavies over 3,000 years ago. There is no wild population of this species anywhere
Adult size	8 to 12 in (20 to 30 cm)
Adult weight	Boars 900 to 1,200 g (2 to 2.6 lb); sows 700 to 900 g (1.5 to 2 lb)
Lifespan	4 to 8 years, with 6 to 8 typical under good care. Diet, companionship and access to an exotics vet are what move it
Diet type	Strict herbivore and hindgut fermenter. Hay is 70 to 80% of the diet. Page 12
Vitamin C	Cannot make its own. 10 to 25 mg per kg of body weight daily for a healthy adult, 30 mg/kg or more when growing, pregnant, nursing or ill. Page 13
Floor space, one pig	7.5 sq ft (0.7 m ²) minimum, plus 2 to 4 sq ft for each additional animal
Floor space, a pair	10.5 sq ft (1 m ²) is the widely used welfare target. Page 5
Room temperature	65 to 79°F (18 to 26°C) at 30 to 60% humidity. Never above 80°F (27°C). Page 7
Social needs	Kept in pairs or small groups. A solo guinea pig is a welfare problem, not a preference. Page 9
Sexual maturity	Sows can conceive from 4 to 5 weeks old. Separate mixed litters by 3 weeks. Page 17
Vocal range	Over eleven distinct calls. Wheeking, purring, rumbling, chutting, teeth chattering. Page 11
Handling difficulty	Beginner, but a prey animal that must be supported at both ends and handled low to the ground
Vaccines required	None for this species

Cost overview

Initial setup, for a pair

\$265 to \$515 for the enclosure and equipment, plus \$20 to \$120 for the pigs themselves and \$100 to \$200 for two first vet exams. Page 31.

Monthly ongoing, a pair

\$80 to \$190. Hay, fresh vegetables and bedding are the three big lines, and they are consumed constantly rather than bought once.

THE NUMBER THAT SURPRISES PEOPLE

Guinea pigs are cheap to acquire and expensive to run. The animal is the smallest line in the budget and the hay is one of the largest, because a guinea pig eats roughly its own body size in hay every day and it never stops. Budget for two animals from the start rather than adding a second later and being surprised by the jump.

Enclosure size, shape & flooring

Measured in square feet of unobstructed floor, not in the label on the box.

Guinea pigs are ground animals. They do not climb, they do not use height, and they run in short bursts along the floor, so the only measurement that means anything is unobstructed floor area. The Merck Veterinary Manual gives a minimum of **7.5 sq ft (0.7 m²) for one guinea pig, plus roughly 2 to 4 sq ft for each additional animal**. The welfare figure in wide use for a bonded pair is **10.5 sq ft (1 m²)**, and since a pair is the normal way to keep this species, that is the number to buy against.

GROUP	FLOOR AREA	ROUGHLY
One guinea pig	7.5 sq ft (0.7 m ²)	30×36 in (76×91 cm)
A bonded pair	10.5 sq ft (1 m ²)	30×50 in (76×127 cm)
Three	13 sq ft (1.2 m ²)	30×62 in (76×158 cm)
Four	16 sq ft (1.5 m ²)	30×76 in (76×193 cm)

WHAT DOES NOT WORK, AND WHY

Wire or mesh flooring. A solid floor is essential, because wire causes pododermatitis and foot and limb injuries. This is not a comfort preference. Page 25.

Glass aquariums and plastic bins. Not recommended: ventilation is poor and ammonia from urine builds up at floor level, where the animal breathes.

Multi-level cages with ramps. An upper shelf is not floor space for a species that does not climb, and a ramp is a fall risk for an animal with a fragile spine.

Anything sold as a "guinea pig starter cage." Almost all of them are under 4 sq ft. They are hamster cages with a different picture on the box.

What to buy instead

A C&C enclosure, built from wire storage cubes and a corrugated plastic base, is what most rescues and welfare organizations recommend, because it gives real square footage for the price of a small commercial cage and it can be extended as the group grows. A large commercial habitat around 8 sq ft is the ready-made alternative. Either way the sides need to be at least 12 in (30 cm) high, which is enough: a guinea pig does not jump, and a lid is only needed where a cat or a dog lives in the house.

Where it goes

- **A room the household uses.** Guinea pigs are social with people as well as with each other, and a garage or spare room is isolation.
- **Out of direct sun and off a draft.** Both are on page 7, and the sun one is genuinely dangerous.
- **Off the floor if there is a dog or a cat,** and out of the path of a vacuum cleaner or a slamming door. A prey animal reads all of it.
- **Somewhere you can carry hay to and bedding from** twice a week without resentment. The setup you can actually maintain is better than the ideal one you cannot.
- **Not outdoors, in most climates.** An outdoor hutch exposes the animals to temperature swings, predators and flies, all of which this species handles badly.

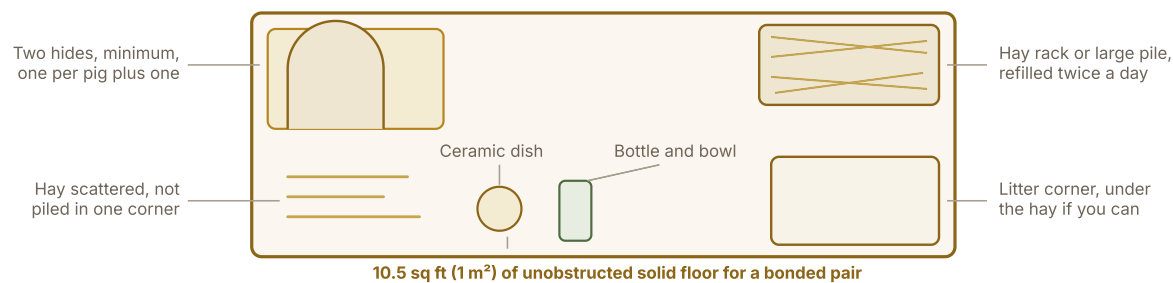
Bedding, hides & cage layout

What goes on the floor, what goes on top of it, and where.

Bedding

Bedding should be recycled paper product, fleece, or another material free of loose fibers and strings. **Wood shavings and chips should be avoided**, because the aromatic oils are associated with respiratory irritation and disease; cedar is the worst and raw pine is not much better. Kiln-dried pine is the one wood product that is generally considered acceptable, since the drying drives off most of the oils, but paper and fleece avoid the question entirely.

OPTION	TRADE-OFF
Paper bedding	Best odor control and the most forgiving if you cannot clean often. Ongoing cost, and it is the largest single consumable after hay
Fleece liners	Cheapest over a year and comfortable underfoot. Needs washing every 2 to 3 days, needs an absorbent layer underneath, and needs sweeping daily or it holds moisture against the feet
Kiln-dried pine	Acceptable, cheap, and dusty. Avoid entirely if any pig has a respiratory history
Cedar, raw pine, sawdust	Not acceptable at any price



Hides, and why there is always one spare

A hide is not decoration. A prey animal with nowhere to retreat stays on alert even in a completely calm room, and research on captive guinea pig welfare links secure hiding options directly to lower stress indicators. **Provide one hide per guinea pig plus one extra**, and give every hide two openings. A single hide in a shared cage becomes something one animal guards rather than something both can use, and a one-door tunnel becomes a place a lower-ranking pig gets cornered.

WATER: OFFER BOTH A BOTTLE AND A BOWL

Bottles stay clean and are easy to read for volume; bowls are how a guinea pig naturally drinks and let a sick animal drink without effort. Offering both removes the failure mode where a blocked or airlocked bottle goes unnoticed for a day. Check the bottle actually runs every morning by touching the ball, and wash both weekly.

Temperature, heat stress & household climate

This is a health page, not a comfort page. Heat kills guinea pigs.

Guinea pigs have no sweat glands, so they cannot lose heat by sweating, and a caged animal in a cage cannot move somewhere cooler. Merck gives the range as **65 to 79°F (18 to 26°C) at 30 to 60% humidity**, and VCA puts the ceiling for a rodent enclosure at **80°F (27°C)**. Treat 80°F as the line. The RSPCA adds the shape either side of it: heat stress can begin as low as 75°F (24°C) and is most commonly seen above 82°F (28°C), and it puts the genuinely comfortable band narrower still, at 64 to 73°F (18 to 23°C). A cheap digital thermometer and hygrometer next to the cage removes all the guesswork, and it is the single most useful \$15 item in this book.

SIGNS OF HEAT STRESS, IN ORDER

Short, rapid breathing or panting. Drooling or slobbering. Weakness and reluctance to move. Pale gums. Then convulsions, collapse and death. Before any of that, the Blue Cross point: a pig lying stretched flat with its back feet trailing behind it is telling you it is too warm and wants help cooling down. It is not relaxing.

IF YOU FIND A PIG OVERHEATING

Move it somewhere cool immediately and dampen the fur with cool, not cold and not iced, water. Cold water can send a small, already stressed animal into shock, and direct contact with ice burns thin skin, which is why a frozen bottle always goes in a towel. Then **go to the vet**, without waiting to see whether it improves: the RSPCA describes treatment as supportive, oxygen and intravenous fluids while cooling the patient, and a pig that looks recovered can still be in trouble internally.

Keeping a room cool without air conditioning

- Move the cage to the coolest room in the house, usually a north-facing ground-floor one.
- Close curtains and blinds on the sunny side in the morning, before the room heats.
- Ceramic or stone tiles in the cage. They pull heat out of an animal lying on them and cost nothing.
- Frozen water bottles wrapped in a towel, placed so the pigs can choose to lie against them or not.
- A fan moving air across the room, never blowing directly at the cage.
- Extra water, in more than one container, and water-heavy foods: cucumber, romaine, melon and apple.

Cold and drafts

Cold is much less dangerous than heat for a healthy adult in a normal house, but drafts are a genuine risk factor for respiratory infection, which is a leading cause of death in this species. Keep the cage off cold exterior walls and away from doors, windows that get opened, and air-conditioning vents. Extra hay and a covered hide are what a pig actually uses to stay warm. Never use a heat pad inside the cage: a guinea pig cannot reliably move away from one and it will chew the cord.

LIGHT AND ROUTINE

Guinea pigs need no special lighting, but they do need a predictable day. They are crepuscular by preference, most active in the morning and evening, and they sleep in short bursts rather than one long block, which means a cage in a room that is dark and silent for sixteen hours is as unnatural as one lit all night. A normal household rhythm suits them.

Common mistakes, enrichment & floor time

Ten things that go wrong most, and the one behavior worth building everything around.

THE MISTAKE	WHAT TO DO INSTEAD
A pet-shop cage under 4 sq ft	Buy floor area in square feet. Page 5
One guinea pig, kept alone	Two, from the start. Page 9
Rabbit pellets, or a colorful muesli mix	Plain guinea-pig pellets with stabilized vitamin C. Page 15
Relying on the pellet bag for vitamin C	Fresh vegetables daily. Page 13
Vitamin C drops in the water bottle	Never. It degrades and it puts pigs off drinking. Page 13
Cedar or raw pine shavings	Paper or fleece. Page 6
A wire cage floor	Solid floor, always. Page 5
The cage in a conservatory or a sunny window	Move it today. Page 7
Hay piled in one corner, refilled when it runs out	Scattered, and never allowed to run out. Page 12
Waiting overnight to see if a pig starts eating again	Call at 8 to 12 hours. Page 18

Foraging first

Wild cavies spend up to 80% of the day foraging and feeding, and a bowl removes the entire behavior. Restoring it is free. **Scatter the hay across the enclosure rather than piling it in one place**, which does double duty as diet and enrichment because hay should be unlimited anyway. Hide chopped vegetables in a foraging mat, a wooden puzzle feeder, or under a layer of hay rather than in a dish, and change where they go every few days so it stays a search.

Chew items

Guinea pig teeth grow continuously, all of them, so gnawing is a physical requirement rather than a pastime. Untreated apple or willow wood, hay-based chew sticks, plain cardboard tubes and boxes, and seagrass mats all hold up. Rotate two or three at a time; individual pigs are surprisingly particular about what they will actually chew. Hay does most of the dental work, and no chew toy substitutes for it.

Floor time, and proofing the room

Even a correctly sized enclosure cannot replace open floor. Supervised time in a proofed room or a playpen lets a guinea pig run, popcorn, and investigate new smells and textures. Twenty minutes to an hour daily is a reasonable target.

- Every cable moved, covered or unplugged. Chewing a live cable is the commonest way floor time goes wrong.
- Gaps blocked: under sofas, behind appliances, into a cupboard. A pig that gets behind something will not come out.
- Houseplants out of the room. If you cannot identify one, it goes.
- Other pets shut out, doors closed, and everyone in the house told the pigs are out.
- A hide in the pen, so there is somewhere to bolt to.

POPCORNING

A sudden vertical jump with a twist, often repeated across the floor. It is play, it is a sign of a comfortable animal, and it is most common in young pigs and after a cage clean or the start of floor time. Older pigs do it less. Nothing is wrong with a pig that does not popcorn, but a pig that used to and has stopped is worth a second look.

Pairs and groups: choosing your guinea pigs

The decision that shapes everything else, and the one where the honest answer is not a preference.

Guinea pigs are herd animals descended from cavies that lived in groups, and a solitary guinea pig is an anxious, understimulated animal that tends toward withdrawal and depression. Nearly every credible welfare source recommends pairs or small groups, and several countries require it by law. A bonded pair chases, grooms, follows and talks to each other all day. A solo pig sits and waits. The difference is not subtle and it is visible within a week of a pair being introduced.

Which combination

PAIRING	WHAT TO EXPECT
Two sows	The easiest pairing and the usual recommendation. Rumbling and mounting for a few days as a hierarchy settles is normal, not fighting
Two boars	Works well when they are littermates or both young, or when an adult is paired with a baby. Needs more floor space and two of everything. Adding a third boar is where trouble usually starts
Neutered boar with one or more sows	Often the most stable long-term group. The boar must be neutered and then given at least four to six weeks before he goes near a sow, because he stays fertile after surgery. Page 17
Intact boar with a sow	Do not. Guinea pig pregnancy carries real risk to the sow, sows can conceive from 4 to 5 weeks old, and a sow bred for the first time after about 6 to 9 months faces a serious complication. Page 17
With a rabbit	No. Different dietary needs, different language, a size mismatch that injures the guinea pig, and rabbits can carry <i>Bordetella</i> without symptoms while it causes fatal pneumonia in guinea pigs. Page 22

Where to get them

A rescue is the best starting point and usually the cheapest: rescue pigs are already sexed correctly by someone who knows how, often already bonded as a pair, and typically health-checked. Pet shops mis-sex guinea pigs often enough that a surprise litter is a well-known outcome, and shop pigs are frequently sold too young. A breeder is worth it if you want a specific coat type. Wherever they come from, check the sex yourself using page 17 before the two of them share a cage.

What to look at before you take one home

- Bright eyes with no discharge, and a dry nose.
- Clean, dry fur with no bald patches, scabs or crusting.
- Breathing quiet and even. No clicking, no snuffling.
- A clean, dry rear end. Staining means diarrhea, recent or current.
- Alert and interested, moving normally on all four feet.
- Eating hay while you watch. It is the single best sign there is.

QUARANTINE, AND IT IS NOT OPTIONAL EVEN WHEN THEY LOOK FINE

A new guinea pig entering a household that already has pigs is kept in a separate room for two to three weeks before any introduction, on separate bedding, with separate hands or a wash between.

Ringworm and mange mites are the two things this catches, and both are miserable to clear once they are in a group. Ringworm also transfers to people. Page 25.

Introducing & bonding two guinea pigs

Most introductions work. The ones that fail usually failed at the setup, not at the pigs.

Two guinea pigs meeting for the first time have to establish which of them is dominant, and they do that with noise and posture. Most of what alarms a first-time owner during an introduction is normal negotiation. The job is to give them a space where negotiating is easy and cornering is impossible, then let them get on with it.

The sequence

1. **Quarantine finishes first.** Two to three weeks, separate room. Page 9.
2. **Cages side by side for several days.** They can smell and hear each other without contact. Swap a hide between the cages so each smells of the other.
3. **Neutral ground.** A pen or a floor area neither pig has used, set up fresh: no hides with one entrance, several piles of hay spread out, two water sources, and vegetables scattered widely so eating happens side by side. Neutral is the single most important word on this page.
4. **Let them run.** Sit and watch for one to two hours. Do not intervene for noise.
5. **A cleaned cage, then together.** Strip the resident cage completely, wash everything, rearrange the layout, and put them in together. It has to stop smelling like one pig's territory.
6. **Watch for the first 48 hours** and keep a spare cage assembled for another week.

Normal negotiation, leave it alone

- Rumbling and rumble-strutting, a low purr with a swaying walk.
- Mounting, in either sex and either direction.
- Teeth chattering, raised heads, wide yawns showing teeth.
- Chasing in short bursts, nose-to-nose standoffs.

Separate now

- A lunge with teeth that connects, or any blood.
- Two pigs locked together, rolling, not breaking apart.
- Fur pulled out in mouthfuls.
- One pig unable to reach food, water or a hide.

NEVER BREAK UP A FIGHT WITH BARE HANDS

A guinea pig bite through a finger web is a deep, dirty puncture. Use a dustpan, a piece of card or a towel dropped over both animals. Keep oven gloves near the pen during an introduction and you will never have to think about it.

Two of everything, permanently

Most conflict in an established pair is about there being one of something. Two hides with two doorways each, two water sources, two hay piles at opposite ends, and a bowl big enough that two heads fit or two separate bowls. This is also why the floor area on page 5 matters: a pair in a cage that is technically the minimum has nowhere to go when one of them wants space.

IF IT GENUINELY DOES NOT WORK

A small number of pairings fail, most often two adult boars introduced late. That is not a reason to keep either pig alone. Rescues run bonding services precisely because this happens, and a pig who cannot live with one particular individual will usually live happily with a different one. Two cages side by side, so they can see and talk to each other, is a distant second-best but far better than isolation.

Handling, sounds & body language

Being lifted off the ground is, to a guinea pig's instincts, exactly what a predator does.

Picking one up correctly

1. **Approach from the side, never from above.** A hand descending from overhead is a bird of prey. Come in level, and let the pig see the hand first.
2. **One hand under the chest**, just behind the front legs.
3. **The other hand scoops and supports the hindquarters** at the same time. Both ends, always. A guinea pig's spine is not built to hang.
4. **Bring it in against your chest** so it is supported rather than dangling.

Stay low. Sit on the floor or a bed. A fall from a modest height can be fatal for an animal this size, and there is no version of handling a guinea pig standing up that is worth the risk. Never lift by the limbs, the scruff or loose fur, and never flip one onto its back, which can damage the spine and is highly stressful even when it does not.

CHILDREN

A guinea pig is often the first pet a child is given, and the combination of a squirming animal and unsteady hands is how falls happen. The workable rule is that a child sits on the floor and the guinea pig is placed on their lap by an adult, and is lifted only by an adult. That is not a restriction on the child's relationship with the animal; lap time on the floor is most of what the relationship consists of.

Sounds, which this species has more of than most

SOUND	WHAT IT MEANS
Wheek	A loud rising squeal, almost always about food. It is a learned call rather than an instinct, aimed at you, and it is why the fridge door produces one
Purring, low and slow	Contentment. Usually while being stroked or settling down
Purring, high and short, with the body tense	The opposite. Annoyance or unease. The body posture is what separates the two
Rumbling	A deep vibrating call, often with a swaying strut. Dominance or courtship. Normal, and constant during an introduction
Chutting and chattering	Chutting is contented pottering. Rapid teeth chattering is a genuine warning: back off
Shrieking	Pain or real fear. Investigate immediately
Chirping	A rare, birdlike call that nobody has fully explained. Not a health sign in itself

Stressed

- Freezing completely still
- Burrowing away from your hand, or bolting for a hide
- High-pitched squeaking, struggling to get free

Content

- Loose, sprawled body posture
- Soft chirping or slow purring
- Eating or grooming while you are there

If you see stress signs, put the pig down gently rather than pushing through. Guinea pigs signal clearly and for a long time before they ever bite, which makes them unusually forgiving to learn on. Daily short sessions, growing naturally in length, is how a pig comes to enjoy lap time.

Hay: the 80% nobody budgets for

It is not bedding, it is not filler, and it is the largest line in the budget.

Unlimited grass hay is the most important thing in a guinea pig's diet and should make up **70 to 80% of daily intake**. A guinea pig eats roughly its own body size in hay every day. It does two jobs nothing else does: the long-strand fiber keeps a hindgut fermenter's digestion moving, and the sideways grinding chew wears down teeth that never stop growing. Almost every problem on the health pages traces back to one of those two failing.

HAY	WHO FOR	NOTES
Timothy	Adults, standard	The default. Coarse, low calcium, good stem-to-leaf balance
Orchard grass	Adults	Softer and sweeter. A good choice for a fussy pig, or for an owner allergic to timothy
Meadow or oat hay	Adults, mixed in	Varied texture and seed heads make it interesting. Fine alongside timothy rather than as the only hay
Alfalfa	Under about 6 months, pregnant, nursing, recovering	A legume, not a grass. Higher protein and calcium, which growing and pregnant animals need. Not for healthy adults: it contributes to obesity and the calcium load feeds bladder stones. Page 23

Judging hay, and storing it

- **Green, not yellow or gray.** Yellow hay is sun-bleached and has lost nutritional value.
- **Smells sweet and dry.** Anything musty, sour or dusty goes straight in the bin. Mold is a serious risk to a small herbivore.
- **Mixed stem and leaf.** All leaf is soft and does less dental work; all stem gets refused.
- **Store it loose and dry,** in a cardboard box or a cloth bag, never sealed in plastic, which traps moisture and grows mold.
- **Buy in bulk.** It is the single biggest saving available in guinea pig keeping, and a pair will get through it.

NEVER LET IT RUN OUT, AND NEVER PILE IT IN ONE CORNER

Hay is offered continuously, refilled at least twice a day, and scattered in two or three places rather than heaped in one. Scattering it is free enrichment (page 8), it stops one pig guarding the supply, and it means a shy pig always has somewhere to eat. Pigs also eat hay lying down, so a rack alone is not enough: there should always be a pile on the floor as well.

DIETARY NEOPHOBIA IS REAL IN THIS SPECIES

Guinea pigs fix their food preferences early in life and do not adapt well to sudden changes, so a new hay brand or cut can be refused simply for being unfamiliar. Introduce a new hay by mixing it into the old one over a week or two rather than switching outright, and treat a pig that has genuinely stopped eating hay as a health problem rather than fussiness. Page 18.

Vitamin C: the rule that makes this species different

The one requirement generic small-pet advice always misses.

Guinea pigs are among a small handful of mammals, alongside humans and some primates and fruit bats, that cannot manufacture their own vitamin C. Rabbits can. Hamsters can. Chinchillas can. A guinea pig has no internal reserve to draw on between meals, so the supply has to arrive every single day, from food. Without it, collagen production fails within days to weeks, and collagen is what holds together joints, gums, blood vessels and healing wounds. That is scurvy, and it is on page 21.

REQUIREMENT	AMOUNT
Healthy adult	10 to 25 mg per kg of body weight per day
Growing, pregnant, nursing or ill	30 mg per kg per day or more
Commonly quoted flat figure	10 to 50 mg a day. For a typical 900 g adult the two overlap at roughly 10 to 25 mg

The per-kilogram figure is the one to work from, because it scales with the animal. A 700 g sow and a 1,200 g boar do not need the same dose.

Where it should come from, in order

1. **Fresh vegetables, daily.** Bell pepper is the standout: red, yellow and orange peppers carry substantially more vitamin C than green, and about a quarter of a medium pepper covers most of an adult's daily requirement on its own. Page 14.
2. **Fortified pellets, as a floor rather than the plan.** See the warning below.
3. **A direct supplement**, as tablets or oral drops given by mouth, when a pig is ill, recovering, pregnant, or genuinely refusing vegetables. It closes a gap; it is not the primary route.

NEVER PUT VITAMIN C IN THE WATER

Both of Merck's reasons matter. It oxidizes fast in light and air, so within hours the bottle contains far less than the label promised and the water needs changing constantly. And it makes the water taste unappetizing, which reduces intake, working directly against a species already prone to bladder problems. Merck's wording is that supplementation of vitamin C in the water is not recommended.

WHY FORTIFIED PELLETS ALONE ARE NOT ENOUGH

Pellets are fortified at milling, and vitamin C is notoriously unstable: it degrades with heat, light, air and time, and a meaningful share is gone within weeks even in a sealed bag. **Use pellets within about 90 days of the manufacture date** (our guinea pig tank setup guide carries the same figure), not the sell-by date, buy smaller bags more often than feels necessary, and store them sealed, cool and dark. Relying on a nutrition label as the only vitamin C source is one of the commonest routes to a scurvy case in a household that is feeding a "complete" diet.

THE FIVE-SECOND VERSION

A quarter of a red bell pepper per pig, every day, and the question is closed. Everything else on this page is what to do when that is not possible.

Daily vegetables & greens

One to two cups per pig per day, rotated, and led by bell pepper.

Fresh produce is where the vitamin C actually comes from, and the veterinary guidance is **1 to 2 cups of fresh produce per guinea pig per day**, offered as one or two servings and rotated across several vegetables rather than the same thing every day. Rotation matters for two reasons: it spreads the calcium and oxalate load, which is what the bladder pages care about, and it keeps a species prone to fixed food preferences willing to try things.

TIER	FOODS
DAILY, THE VITAMIN C CORE	Bell pepper, red, yellow or orange for preference (green is fine but lower). Ripe tomato in small amounts. Romaine and other dark leaf lettuces. Cucumber, mostly water but useful in hot weather
DAILY, ROTATED	Cilantro, parsley, dill, basil, endive, escarole, butterhead lettuce, carrot tops, celery leaves, turnip greens, collard greens, asparagus
TWO OR THREE TIMES A WEEK	Kale, spinach, chard, dandelion greens, broccoli, cauliflower leaves, bok choy, zucchini, green beans. All are good food; kale, spinach and chard carry calcium or oxalate loads worth spreading out, and brassicas cause gas in some pigs
SMALL AMOUNTS, OCCASIONALLY	Carrot and celery stalk, both higher in sugar or stringy fiber than they look
NEVER	Iceberg or head lettuce. Almost no nutrition, and enough water to loosen droppings. Page 15 carries the full never list

How to serve it

- **Wash everything.** Guinea pigs are small and eat a lot relative to their weight, so pesticide residue matters more than it would for a person.
- **Chop into pieces a pig can hold,** and scatter or hide it rather than putting it in one dish. Page 8.
- **Serve at room temperature.** Straight from the fridge is a genuine cause of digestive upset in a small herbivore.
- **Take uneaten produce out after 30 minutes to a couple of hours,** sooner in a warm room. Wilted greens are one thing; spoiled greens are a gut problem.
- **Introduce anything new gradually,** one item at a time, in a small amount. Page 12 explains why this species reacts badly to abrupt change.

Grass, and a note about lawns

Fresh grass is excellent food and pigs love it, but only from ground that has never been treated with pesticide, herbicide or fertilizer, and never from anywhere dogs, cats or wild animals use. Pick it by hand rather than mowing: cut grass from a mower heats and begins to ferment within minutes, which is a real cause of bloat. Introduce grass slowly, over a week or two, for a pig that has not had it before.

A WEEKLY PREP, SO THE DAILY VERSION ACTUALLY HAPPENS

Wash and chop a week's worth of the sturdier vegetables on one evening and keep them in a sealed box in the fridge, then take out and warm one portion per pig each morning. Leafy greens go in fresh. The households where fresh food quietly stops after month one are the ones where it needed preparing from scratch every day.

Pellets, fruit, treats & the never-feed list

The smallest part of the diet, and the part with the real dangers in it.

Pellets

Pellets are a supplement to hay, not a replacement, and the portion is small: the veterinary figure is **1 to 2 teaspoons per guinea pig per day**, and popular care guides commonly give about 1/8 cup, roughly 2 tablespoons. Those disagree by a factor of several, and the honest reading is that a guinea pig eating plenty of hay and 1 to 2 cups of fresh produce needs the smaller amount, while the larger figure suits a growing, pregnant or underweight animal. **Start at 1 to 2 teaspoons and let hay intake and body condition decide.** A pig eating all its pellets and little hay is being given too many.

- **Guinea-pig pellets specifically.** Rabbit and other rodent pellets contain no added vitamin C, because those animals make their own.
- **Timothy-based, with stabilized vitamin C on the label**, and used within 90 days of manufacture. Page 13.
- **Plain uniform pellets only.** Anything with seeds, nuts, corn, dried fruit or colored pieces is a muesli mix, and pigs selectively eat the sweet parts and leave the rest.
- **Alfalfa-based pellets** belong with young, pregnant or nursing pigs, not healthy adults. Page 12.

Fruit and treats

Treats of all kinds, fruit included, stay under about 10% of the diet, which for an animal this size means a piece the size of a fingernail rather than a slice. Small amounts of orange, kiwi, apple, pear, strawberry, blueberry or melon are fine a couple of times a week, with pits and seeds removed. There is no commercial treat that is better than a piece of bell pepper, and the yogurt drops, honey sticks and seed bars on the pet shop shelf are actively worse than nothing.

NEVER FEED

Avocado, linked to heart muscle damage.

Onion, garlic, chives and leeks, which can cause destruction of red blood cells, with signs sometimes taking 3 to 5 days to appear.

Rhubarb, high in oxalic acid and linked to bladder stones. **Chocolate.**

Raw potato, unripe tomato, and the leaves or plants of either. Mushrooms. Fruit pits and seeds.

Meat, eggs and dairy. A guinea pig is a strict herbivore; none of it belongs in the cage.

Iceberg lettuce. No nutrition, and enough water to loosen droppings.

NOT TOXIC, STILL WRONG

Oats, seeds, nuts, peanut butter, corn, bread, pasta and dry cereal are all too high in starch or fat. The problem is not poisoning, it is that a guinea pig will pick these over hay and pellets every time, which produces nutrient gaps and obesity in an animal whose whole digestive system depends on eating fiber all day. Bought treat sticks are usually made of exactly these things glued together with honey.

Water

Fresh water available at all times, changed daily, with the bottle and bowl washed weekly to stop a biofilm forming. Check a bottle by pressing the ball every morning rather than by looking at the level: an airlocked bottle looks full. Page 6 explains why offering both a bottle and a bowl is worth the extra minute.

Grooming, nails, coats & boar cleaning

Three routine jobs, and one that only applies to older boars.

Nails

Guinea pig nails grow continuously and there is nothing in a cage that wears them down, so trimming is a permanent part of ownership: Lafeber's interval is **every 6 to 8 weeks**, sooner for a house pig on soft bedding. Take only the tip, clear of the pink quick visible through a pale nail. On a dark nail, hold a torch *behind* it and the quick shows against the light; failing that, take a very small amount at a time and stop as the cut surface changes texture. Keep styptic powder or cornstarch out and open before you start. Front nails grow faster than back ones and curl if left, and a curled nail grows into the pad.

Coats

Unlike a rabbit, a guinea pig has no seasonal molt: shedding runs low and continuous all year, so loose fur is the baseline.

COAT	GROOMING
Short, smooth (American)	Lafeber's floor for a short coat is every few days, not weekly. A soft brush, and essentially maintenance-free beyond that
Rosetted (Abyssinian)	Every few days. Debris collects in the whorls, so check them rather than just brushing over them
Short and dense (Teddy, Rex)	Every few days. The coarse coat holds bedding; skin underneath is worth checking for dryness
Long (Peruvian, Silkie, Sheltie, Texel)	Daily brushing, and the rear kept trimmed short permanently. A long coat over the rear mats with urine and droppings and is a common route to skin infection and flystrike. Many owners keep long-haired pigs in a permanent short clip, a kindness rather than a compromise

BATHS, RARELY AND NEVER ROUTINELY

Merck's position: a bath is rarely needed unless the pig is visibly soiled, and when one is necessary the water stays shallow enough that she only stands in it, belly level, never submerged. Wash a soiled rear end, or the whole animal on a vet's prescription. Small-animal shampoo, no human product, dried thoroughly in a warm draft-free room. A damp guinea pig chills fast, and chilling is a respiratory risk. Page 22.

Boar cleaning

Male guinea pigs have a rectal pouch, a pocket just behind the anus, and in older intact boars it commonly becomes impacted with softened droppings he can no longer clear. Owners call it boar butt. It smells, causes local irritation and infection, and has been linked to urinary tract infections. Check any boar over about two weekly, tipping him gently back on your lap to look. If the pouch is full, clean it with a cotton swab and a little mineral oil or a vet-recommended cleanser, slowly, stopping if he objects strongly. Ask your vet to show you once; it is easier demonstrated than described.

The grease gland is separate, and both sexes have one, at the base of the spine just above the tail area. It is more active in boars, and it gets greasy, matted and smelly. Lafeber's lighter option for light buildup is a cotton swab and a mild cleaning agent. For a gland that has caked, coconut oil worked in to loosen the wax, then a small-animal shampoo and a thorough rinse. It is cosmetic rather than medical unless the skin underneath is inflamed, in which case page 25 applies.

Sexing, neutering & the breeding deadline

Mis-sexing is common, and the consequences arrive fast.

How to sex a guinea pig

Sit down, rest the pig on your lap with its back against you so it is upright and supported, and look at the genital area with the animal's rear tipped gently toward you. Press very lightly just above the opening with a fingertip.

- **Boar:** gentle pressure above the opening extrudes the penis, and there is a distinct rounded shape you can feel under the skin. The whole area reads as a shallow "i" shape, a small circle above a line.
- **Sow:** the same pressure opens a "Y" shaped slit, and nothing extrudes. The genital opening sits closer to the anus than in a boar.
- Both sexes have nipples, so nipples tell you nothing. Testicles in a young boar are not obvious, so their apparent absence tells you nothing either.

If you are not certain after two goes, the vet will do it in thirty seconds at the first health check, and pet shops get this wrong often enough that a rescue's word is worth more than a shop's label.

THE TIMINGS THAT MAKE THIS URGENT

A sow can conceive from 4 to 5 weeks old, and boars start mounting at about a month. Mixed-sex litters are separated by three weeks of age, no later, and that includes separating a young boar from his own mother. Gestation is 59 to 72 days, averaging 68, which is very long for a rodent, and a litter is usually 2 to 4 but can be as many as 13. A sow can also be mated again within hours of giving birth.

WHY A FIRST LITTER AFTER ABOUT 6 TO 9 MONTHS IS DANGEROUS

A guinea pig's pubic symphysis, the cartilage joint at the front of the pelvis, stays flexible in a sow who has given birth, but in one who has not it ossifies and fuses over her first year. After that the pelvic canal cannot widen enough to pass a guinea pig's very large, fully-furred, open-eyed newborns, and a natural birth becomes impossible: the outcome is obstructed labor and a caesarean, or death. This is the single strongest reason not to keep an intact boar and a sow together and hope. It is also why "we will just let her have one litter" is a bad plan for an adult rescue sow of unknown history.

Neutering

Neutering in guinea pigs is done on boars, not sows: a sow spay is major abdominal surgery reserved for a medical reason such as ovarian cysts (page 24), while a boar castration is comparatively straightforward. It does not change temperament and it is not a solution to a boar-boar conflict; the reason to do it is to allow a boar to live with sows.

THE FOUR TO SIX WEEK RULE

A neutered boar stays fertile for weeks after surgery while sperm already present clears. **Keep him away from any sow for at least four to six weeks after the operation**, and ask your vet for their own figure. Litters conceived a fortnight after a castration are a well-known and entirely avoidable event. Anesthesia in this species also carries real risk and needs a vet who does it regularly. Page 27.

Health red flags & the 8 to 12 hour rule

For most pets, a skipped meal is nothing. For this one it is the alarm.

A guinea pig is a hindgut fermenter whose digestion depends on food moving through continuously. When eating stops, the gut slows, and a slowed gut is both a cause and a consequence of not eating, so the situation compounds rather than plateaus. **The point to call a vet is 8 to 12 hours without eating or without producing droppings**, and once gastrointestinal stasis is established it can become life-threatening within 24 to 48 hours. With prompt treatment many guinea pigs start improving within 24 to 72 hours, which is the argument for calling early rather than watching.

SAME DAY, NO WAITING

Not eating, or eating noticeably less, for 8 to 12 hours.

No droppings, or droppings suddenly small, dry or few.

Labored breathing, open-mouth breathing, or any clicking or wheezing. Guinea pigs are obligate nasal breathers and cannot fall back on mouth breathing.

A hunched, tense posture, or audible teeth grinding, which is pain.

A bloated or firm abdomen.

Lying stretched flat, panting or drooling in warm weather. Page 7.

Straining to urinate, blood in the urine, or crying while urinating. Page 23.

Diarrhea, or a wet, soiled rear end.

Any sudden loss of coordination, head tilt, or seizure.

Within a few days

- Weight down more than 5% off the pig's own baseline
- Drooling, a wet chin, or dropping food while chewing
- Hair loss, scabs, or intense scratching
- A new lump anywhere, particularly on the neck
- Limping, stiffness, or reluctance to move
- Discharge from eyes or nose, or repeated sneezing
- A pig that has stopped popcorning or stopped talking
- Hair loss along the flanks in a sow. Page 24

Normal values worth knowing

MEASURE	NORMAL
Body temperature	99 to 101.5°F (37.2 to 38.6°C)
Heart rate	230 to 380 beats per minute
Respiratory rate	40 to 100 breaths per minute, quiet and through the nose
Weight	Boars 900 to 1,200 g, sows 700 to 900 g, and stable against the animal's own baseline

WHAT TO HAVE READY WHEN YOU CALL

Current weight and usual weight. When it last ate, and what. When you last saw a normal dropping. What the droppings look like now. Whether it is drinking. Any change in the last week: new food, new bedding, a new cage mate, a hot day. Take the sitter sheet's line seriously here too: photograph the cage floor before you clean it. Write the vet's number and an after-hours number on page 30 today.

GI stasis, bloat & a pig that stops eating

The emergency this species is most likely to have, and the one with the shortest fuse.

Gastrointestinal stasis is the gut slowing or stopping. It follows from inadequate fiber, dehydration, pain from anywhere in the body, stress, or a sudden diet change, and it then feeds itself: a pig that hurts stops eating, and a pig that stops eating hurts more. Bloat is the related emergency in which gas accumulates faster than it can be passed, distending the abdomen and pressing on the diaphragm. Both are urgent. Neither is treatable at home.

The seven reasons a guinea pig stops eating

1. **Dental disease.** The most commonly cited cause by a distance, and usually invisible without a vet's examination because the problem is at the back of the mouth. Page 20.
2. **GI stasis itself**, once it is under way.
3. **Pain or illness elsewhere.** Respiratory infection, bladder stones, arthritis or an injury all suppress appetite as a secondary sign.
4. **Environmental stress.** A new home, a moved cage, a new cage mate, building noise. Real, and usually short-lived, but never assume it.
5. **Dietary neophobia.** A new hay or pellet brand refused because it is unfamiliar. Page 12.
6. **Pregnancy toxemia**, in an overweight or late-term sow. Page 24.
7. **Vitamin C deficiency.** Reduced appetite is one of the earliest signs and appears within 2 to 3 weeks of a deficient diet. Page 21.

SIGNS, AND THE LINE

Reduced or absent droppings, or droppings gone small and dry. Lethargy or reluctance to move. A hunched or tense posture. Audible teeth grinding. A bloated or firm abdomen, sometimes with a hollow drum sound when tapped very gently. Reduced drinking. Labored breathing as a distended gut presses upward. **Call at 8 to 12 hours without food or droppings.** Not tomorrow morning.

What the vet will do

Assisted feeding with a syringe of recovery formula is the core of it, alongside pain relief, fluids, and a prokinetic drug to restart gut movement where appropriate. An x-ray distinguishes gas from an obstruction, which matters because a true obstruction is a surgical problem and gas is not. Underlying causes are chased at the same time, and the teeth are always checked. Recovery generally begins within 24 to 72 hours of treatment starting.

SYRINGE FEEDING AT HOME, ONLY UNDER DIRECTION

Your vet will likely send you home syringe-feeding a critical care formula every few hours, including overnight. Two things make it safer: give small amounts and let the pig chew and swallow at its own pace rather than pushing the plunger, and aim the syringe into the side of the mouth behind the incisors, never straight down the throat. A guinea pig that is fighting hard is a guinea pig at risk of inhaling the food. Stop, wait, and try again in ten minutes. **Keep a syringe and a bag of recovery formula in the house before you need them;** it is the one supply that is always needed at the worst possible hour.

Dental disease & malocclusion

Every tooth grows for life, and the ones that go wrong are the ones you cannot see.

A guinea pig's incisors, premolars and molars all grow continuously. The front teeth are easy to look at and are rarely the whole story; the cheek teeth at the back are where malocclusion usually starts, and in this species the lower cheek teeth characteristically overgrow inward and **bridge over the tongue**, trapping it so the animal cannot swallow properly. An owner sees a pig that has gone off its food and looks otherwise normal.

SIGNS, WHICH ARE NONSPECIFIC AND THAT IS THE PROBLEM

Anything from mild pickiness to a complete refusal to eat. Difficulty chewing or swallowing. Drooling, or a permanently wet chin and chest, which is the classic one. Dropping food after picking it up. Preferring soft foods and abandoning hay. Weight loss. Reduced activity. Unusually small droppings, because less is going in.

Why it happens

Teeth stay the right length by grinding against each other, and the grinding comes almost entirely from chewing hay sideways. A pig on a pellet-and-vegetable diet with hay as an afterthought does not do enough of that motion, and the teeth drift out of alignment. Once they are out of alignment they wear unevenly, which makes the misalignment worse. That is the whole mechanism, and it is why page 12 is the prevention for this page. Vitamin C deficiency also affects the ligaments that hold the teeth in their sockets, which is a second route to the same place, and injury or a genetic jaw fault are the less common ones.

Treatment, and what to expect

Diagnosis needs a proper examination, which means an otoscope or endoscope and usually sedation: a conscious guinea pig's mouth is a narrow tube and the important teeth are at the far end of it. Treatment is crown reduction and correction of the occlusal angle under anesthesia, and severely diseased teeth are extracted. **Chronic cases often need the procedure repeated every 4 to 6 weeks**, which is why prevention is worth so much: this is a lifelong, recurring cost once it starts. Ask directly whether the practice has the equipment and does this routinely, because a general small-animal clinic often does not.

WHAT YOU CAN ACTUALLY CHECK AT HOME

Look at the incisors weekly: the top pair should be shorter than the bottom pair and meet squarely, not splay sideways or cross over. Feel along the jawline for lumps, which can be root overgrowth pushing down through the bone. Then weigh the pig, because the real early-warning system for a problem you cannot see is a number that has started falling. Page 28.

NEVER TRIM A GUINEA PIG'S TEETH YOURSELF

Clipping incisors with nail clippers shatters the tooth lengthwise and can split it into the root, causing an abscess. It is done with a dental burr, under anesthesia, by a vet. Anything sold for home use should be ignored.

Scurvy: stages, treatment & recovery

The most common preventable illness in pet guinea pigs, and the easiest to miss early.

Page 13 covers the requirement. This page is what happens when it is not met. Without dietary vitamin C, collagen production breaks down over days to weeks, and collagen is structural: it holds together joints, gum tissue, blood vessel walls and healing wounds. The clinical picture follows exactly from that. The early signs are vague enough to be blamed on age, weather or mood, which is why this remains common in households that believe they are feeding well.

STAGE	WHAT YOU SEE
EARLY	A rough or puffed coat that has lost its lie. Mild lethargy. Slightly reduced appetite. PetMD's figure is that 2 to 3 weeks of an insufficient diet is all it takes for signs to set in. Subtle stiffness on standing up
PROGRESSING	Swollen, painful joints. Reluctance to move or to bear weight, sometimes read as laziness. Difficulty picking food up. Weight loss. Wounds that will not close
ADVANCED	Bleeding gums. Spontaneous bruising. Bleeding into the joints. Diarrhea. A genuine emergency at this point

The veterinary description of the presentation is anorexia or difficulty picking up food, a rough coat, lameness or partial paralysis, swollen joints, generalized pain, and delayed wound healing. A pig that hurts everywhere often looks, to an owner, like a pig that has become unfriendly.

Treatment

This is a vet visit, not a wait-and-see, and particularly so once joint pain or gum bleeding is visible. Treatment is three things together: correcting the husbandry that caused it, vitamin C given by mouth or by injection at a therapeutic dose the vet calculates, and pain relief, because scurvy hurts and a pig in pain does not eat. Assisted feeding is often needed alongside, because the animal has usually been eating poorly for a while by the time it is diagnosed. Page 19.

Recovery

Early and moderate cases often improve within one to two weeks of proper treatment. Advanced cases with real joint damage take longer and can leave lasting stiffness, which is the strongest argument for catching this early rather than after the signs are unmistakable. Recovery is also the point at which to fix the underlying routine for good, because a pig that has had scurvy once is in a household where the daily vegetable habit did not hold.

DO NOT TREAT A SUSPECTED CASE YOURSELF WITH A PET-SHOP SUPPLEMENT

Therapeutic dosing is different from maintenance dosing and it is calculated on body weight. More importantly, the early signs of scurvy overlap almost exactly with the early signs of dental disease, arthritis and pain from a bladder stone, and treating a stone with vitamin C wastes the time the animal has. Get the diagnosis, then fix the diet.

THE PREVENTION, RESTATED

A quarter of a red bell pepper per pig per day, fresh, alongside unlimited hay and a small measured portion of in-date pellets. That is the entire intervention. Nothing on this page happens in a household that does that.

Respiratory infection & pneumonia

A leading cause of death in this species, and it moves fast.

Pneumonia is a leading cause of death in guinea pigs, especially in young ones, and it is usually bacterial. *Bordetella bronchiseptica* and *Streptococcus pneumoniae* are the two agents named most often. Respiratory infections here progress quickly, and there is one anatomical fact that makes them more dangerous than they would be in another animal: **guinea pigs are obligate nasal breathers**. They cannot switch to breathing through the mouth when the nose blocks. An open-mouthed guinea pig is in serious trouble.

SAME-DAY SIGNS

Sneezing, especially repeatedly. Discharge from the nose or eyes, or crusting around either. Any noise on breathing: clicking, wheezing, rattling. Labored breathing, or the flanks visibly working. Open-mouth breathing. Loss of appetite and lethargy alongside any of the above. A pig sitting hunched with its neck extended.

Where it comes from

- **Drafts and damp.** The commonest environmental contributor and the easiest to fix. Page 7.
- **Ammonia from bedding** that is not changed often enough, concentrated at floor level where the animal breathes. This is also why glass tanks are a poor choice. Page 6.
- **Dust**, from wood shavings, very dusty hay, or a cage in a busy room being swept around.
- **Rabbits.** A rabbit can carry *Bordetella* without any signs at all and pass it to a guinea pig, in whom it causes fatal pneumonia. This is the concrete reason not to house the two species together, over and above the dietary and size mismatch. Page 9.
- **Stress and crowding**, particularly in a newly bought young pig that has been through a shop.
- **Vitamin C deficiency**, which suppresses the immune response. Page 21.

Treatment

Antibiotics, chosen carefully, plus supportive care: fluids, warmth, assisted feeding, and sometimes oxygen and nebulization. The choice of antibiotic matters enormously in this species and page 26 is the page to take with you. Treatment courses are typically longer than an owner expects, and stopping early because the pig looks better is a common route to a relapse with a harder infection.

A SNEEZE IS NOT ALWAYS AN INFECTION, BUT IT IS ALWAYS WORTH WATCHING

Hay dust, a dusty bedding change and a stray strand up the nose all produce an isolated sneeze in a completely healthy pig. What separates that from the start of something is repetition, discharge, and any change in appetite or activity. One sneeze on a Tuesday is nothing. Sneezing several times a day for two days is a call.

Bladder stones & urinary disease

Common, painful, and the one area where the daily vegetable list has consequences.

Guinea pigs form urinary stones readily, and the stones are typically **calcium carbonate** and related crystals. This is a species that excretes surplus calcium through the kidneys rather than storing or discarding it another way, so a persistently high calcium load in the diet ends up in the bladder as sediment and then as stones. Blood in the urine, hematuria, is a characteristic finding.

SIGNS

Straining in the litter corner, often in a hunched position, sometimes for a long time with little produced. A squeak or cry while urinating, which is the sign owners remember. Blood in the urine or pink staining on the bedding. Frequent small urinations. A wet or stained rear end. Loss of appetite and lethargy alongside. **A pig straining and producing nothing at all is a blockage and is an emergency now**, because a fully obstructed bladder is fatal within hours to a day.

What raises the risk

FACTOR	WHAT TO DO
Alfalfa hay or alfalfa pellets in an adult	The single biggest dietary lever. Grass hay and timothy-based pellets for any healthy adult. Page 12
The same high-calcium greens every day	Kale, spinach, parsley and chard are all good food. Rotate them rather than feeding one daily, which is what page 14's tiers are for
Low water intake	Dilute urine is the best protection there is. Offer both a bottle and a bowl, keep water fresh, and never flavor it. Page 13 explains why vitamin C in the water works against this
Hard tap water	Worth considering if a pig has already had stones. Ask your vet before switching to filtered water rather than doing it on your own
Obesity and inactivity	A pig that moves less empties its bladder less completely. Floor time is a urinary intervention as well as an enrichment one. Page 8

Diagnosis and treatment

Urinalysis and an x-ray, since these stones are radiopaque and show clearly. A stone in the bladder is removed surgically; there is no dietary way to dissolve a formed calcium carbonate stone, and delaying only lets it grow. Sludge without a formed stone is sometimes managed with fluids, pain relief and dietary change. Recurrence is common, so a pig that has had one stone gets a permanently reviewed diet and periodic rechecks. Cystitis without stones also occurs and is treated with antibiotics chosen with page 26 in mind.

WHITE CHALKY URINE IS NOT AUTOMATICALLY A PROBLEM

Guinea pig urine dries to a chalky white or cream residue on bedding, because of the calcium carbonate it normally carries. That in itself is normal. What is not normal is gritty sediment, pink or red staining, or a pig that is uncomfortable while producing it. Page 28 covers the daily version of this check.

Ovarian cysts & reproductive disease

Very common in sows, easy to see once you know the sign, and often silent until then.

Ovarian cysts

Ovarian cysts are the most common reproductive tract disorder in guinea pig sows, and they are common enough that any middle-aged or older intact sow with vague signs deserves to be assessed for them. Fluid-filled cysts develop on one or both ovaries, and because some of them produce hormones, the effects reach well beyond the abdomen.

THE SIGN THAT GIVES IT AWAY

Symmetrical hair loss along both flanks, running down each side of the body, with the skin underneath looking normal rather than inflamed or scabby. That pattern in a sow is ovarian cysts until proven otherwise, and it is what separates this from mites, which itch and damage the skin (page 25). Other signs are a swollen or pear-shaped abdomen, crusty or enlarged nipples, reduced appetite, lethargy, and a sow becoming unusually grumpy or aggressive with a cage mate.

Diagnosis is by ultrasound. Treatment options are hormonal, which shrinks some cysts and can be a reasonable choice for an older sow, draining, which usually refills, or ovariectomy, which is definitive and also removes the risk of uterine disease later. The surgery is a real abdominal procedure and needs a vet who does guinea pig anesthesia routinely. Page 27.

Pregnancy, and pregnancy toxemia

Guinea pig pregnancy is risky, which is the reason page 17 is written the way it is. Gestation runs 59 to 72 days, averaging 68, and the young are born fully furred with their eyes open and start eating solid food within hours. The two serious complications are the fused pubic symphysis in a sow bred for the first time after about 6 to 9 months, covered on page 17, and pregnancy toxemia.

PREGNANCY TOXEMIA

A metabolic collapse in late pregnancy or just after birth, and it is potentially fatal. The risk is highest in overweight sows and in late-term pregnancy, and it can be triggered by any period of not eating, by stress, or by a sudden change in food. It presents as sudden appetite loss and lethargy in a pregnant or newly delivered sow, and it moves quickly. **Any pregnant sow that goes off her food is an emergency, at once, not at 8 to 12 hours.**

Mammary and other reproductive disease

Mammary tumors occur in both sexes, boars included, and are found as a firm lump near a nipple. They are frequently treatable when caught early and removed, so the weekly hands-on check on page 28 is the thing that catches them. Uterine and cervical disease presents most often as bleeding from the vulva outside of any normal cycle, which is always a vet visit.

Mites, lice, ringworm, lumps & bumblefoot

The outside of the animal, and two of these transfer to you.

Mange mites

Trixacarus caviae is a burrowing mange mite and it causes severe itching. The veterinary description is worth quoting because owners routinely misread it: the scratching can be **so intense that the animal appears to be having a seizure**. A guinea pig that suddenly runs in circles, throws itself over, or shrieks and convulses is very often a mite case rather than a neurological one, and it is one of the most treatable serious-looking things in this book. Hair loss, scabbing and thickened crusted skin along the back and flanks come with it. Mites are often latent in a pig for a long time and flare when the animal is stressed, pregnant, or ill.

TREATMENT

Ivermectin at 0.4 mg/kg by injection under the skin, repeated every 10 to 14 days for four treatments, or selamectin at 15 mg/kg applied to the skin once, are both effective. Treat every pig in the household, not only the one showing signs, and clean and replace bedding and porous cage furniture during treatment. Pain relief matters too: a badly affected pig hurts.

Lice

Guinea pig lice are host-specific, do not live on people, and cause milder disease than mites. You may see them as tiny moving specks along the neck and behind the ears. Heavy infestations produce hair loss and crusted lesions. Treated similarly, and again treat everyone in the cage.

Ringworm

Not a worm but a fungal skin infection, usually *Trichophyton mentagrophytes* or *T. benhamiae*. It appears as circular patches of hair loss with flaky, crusty skin, classically starting around the face, nose and ears and spreading. **It transmits from guinea pigs to humans**, so it is worth diagnosing properly rather than guessing, and worth gloves while treating. Treatment is antifungal, topical or oral depending on extent, together with a thorough environmental clean, and it takes weeks.

Lumps in the neck

Cervical lymphadenitis produces **large, one-sided swellings in the neck**, sometimes called lumps, from infected lymph nodes. Treatment is surgical removal of the affected nodes with systemic antibiotics. Any firm lump anywhere on a guinea pig warrants an appointment: abscesses, cysts, lipomas and tumors all present as a lump and telling them apart is a needle and a microscope, not a look.

BUMBLEFOOT, OR PODODERMATITIS

Inflammation and ulceration of the soles, showing as redness, callus-like swellings, open sores, and eventually cellulitis and deep infection. It is caused by pressure and contamination: wire flooring, damp or dirty bedding, obesity, and hard surfaces with nothing soft to stand on. Early cases are treated with topical care, bandaging, pain relief, vitamin C, and correcting the husbandry that caused it. Advanced cases can reach the bone and are very hard to resolve, which makes the solid clean floor on page 5 a genuinely medical requirement rather than a comfort one. Check the soles during the weekly handling check.

Antibiotics & enterotoxemia

Print this page. It is the one to hand over at a clinic you have not used before.

A guinea pig's gut flora is predominantly Gram-positive, and the fermentation it performs is what digests the animal's food. Antibiotics that act preferentially against Gram-positive organisms wipe out that flora and allow *Clostridioides difficile* to overgrow. It produces two toxins as it does: one damages the cells lining the intestine and floods the gut with fluid, the other kills them outright. The result is antibiotic-associated enterotoxemia, and it kills. This is not a rare idiosyncratic reaction: it is a predictable consequence of the wrong drug in this species, and it is the single most important thing a guinea pig owner can know about veterinary care.

ASK ABOUT THESE BEFORE THE FIRST DOSE, BY ANY ROUTE

Merck names the risky groups by class: **beta lactams** (penicillin, ampicillin, amoxicillin, amoxicillin-clavulanate, cephalosporins), **lincosamides** (clindamycin, lincomycin) and **older macrolides** (erythromycin, tylosin). VCA adds **bacitracin**, **streptomycin** and **procaine-containing injectables**, and says none of them should be given to a rodent by mouth, on the skin or by injection. Amoxicillin is the one worth naming twice, because it is the drug a general practice reaches for first. **Ask, do not refuse:** there are situations where a vet chooses one of these deliberately and manages the risk. What should never happen is it being prescribed without anyone noticing the species.

AND WHAT A VET CAN USUALLY USE INSTEAD

Merck's usable group in guinea pigs is fluoroquinolones, tetracyclines, chloramphenicol, sulfonamide with trimethoprim, and aminoglycosides, because they do less to the Gram-positive flora. That is the shape of the conversation, not your prescription: the vet chooses the drug for the infection in front of them.

Any antibiotic can disturb the flora, so all of them are used with caution here, and route matters too, since an oral dose passes straight through the gut where the flora lives. Enterotoxemia is also triggered by stress, an abrupt diet change, and gastrointestinal stasis itself. Signs are diarrhea, a drop in appetite, lethargy and collapse, appearing during or shortly after a course. Death usually follows 1 to 2 days after the diarrhea starts, so it is an emergency from the first loose dropping.

Anesthesia & the vet conversation

Two things about a guinea pig under anesthetic run opposite to a dog, and neither gets explained.

Questions worth asking, at any clinic

- How many guinea pigs does the practice see in a month?
- Do you anesthetize guinea pigs routinely, and for dentals specifically?
- Do you have the equipment to examine the cheek teeth properly?
- Who is on out-of-hours, and do they see exotics?
- What is your policy on fasting before anesthesia?
- Can I bring a cage mate to the appointment?

TWO THINGS THAT ARE DIFFERENT FROM A DOG OR A CAT

Guinea pigs are not fasted before anesthesia. They cannot vomit, so the reason for fasting a dog does not apply, and a herbivore that stops eating before surgery arrives at the operating table with a slowing gut. Merck asks for **1 to 2 hours** only, and for a narrow reason: guinea pigs hold food in the mouth and cranial esophagus, so the point is clearing the mouth, not emptying the stomach. If a practice tells you to withhold food overnight, ask them to confirm that against exotic-species guidance.

Bring the cage mate, and watch the clock afterwards. Guinea pigs are separated badly, both by the animal that leaves and the one left behind, and a pig recovering alone in a strange room eats less. Most exotics practices will house a companion alongside. Merck's bar for a rabbit is that if it has not eaten within **2 to 3 hours** of surgery the pain relief needs reviewing, and it is a reasonable bar to hold a guinea pig vet to as well.

AND THE EVERYDAY VERSION

A guinea pig recovering from anything eats less than it should, and eating is the whole game in this species. Ask for pain relief as a matter of course rather than only when the animal looks sore, ask about assisted feeding before you leave, and take a syringe and recovery formula home with you.

Droppings, weight & body condition

Two minutes a day and five minutes a week, and they catch nearly everything on the last ten pages.

Droppings

Normal guinea pig droppings are firm, oval, dark brown, uniform in size, and plentiful: a healthy pig produces a great many every day. They are the fastest read you get on how the gut is doing, and reading them is free.

WHAT YOU SEE	WHAT IT USUALLY MEANS
Fewer than usual, or none	The gut is slowing. Page 19. At 8 to 12 hours with none, call
Small, dry, hard, or pointed at one end	Not enough is going in, or not enough water. Often the first sign of dental disease
Soft, clumped or stuck together	Too much fresh food or a sudden diet change, most often. Pull back the vegetables for a day and watch
Truly liquid, or a soiled wet rear	Diarrhea. Not the same as soft droppings, and a same-day call
Slimy, mucus-covered, or with blood	Vet, today
Chalky white residue in the urine patches	Normal calcium carbonate. Gritty sediment or pink staining is not. Page 23

A guinea pig also eats some of its droppings directly from the vent. This is normal and necessary: the caecum produces a softer, nutrient-rich dropping that the animal reingests to absorb what a single pass through the gut misses. An obese, arthritic or long-coated pig that physically cannot reach is missing part of its nutrition, and that is worth a vet conversation rather than a shrug.

Weight, weekly

A digital kitchen scale reading in grams is the most useful diagnostic tool an owner of this species can own. Weigh every pig on the same day each week, at the same time, and write it down.

READING	WHAT TO DO
Stable within about 30 g week to week	Normal fluctuation. Carry on
Down 30 to 50 g, or about 5%	Watch closely, check hay intake and droppings, weigh again in 2 to 3 days
Down more than 50 g, or falling three weeks running	Vet appointment. Dental disease and megabacteria-style quiet losses show here first
Climbing steadily	Too many pellets or too much fruit. Check the portion against page 15

THE WEEKLY HANDS-ON CHECK, DONE WHILE THE PIG IS ON THE SCALE

Feel along the spine and hips: in good condition they are palpable but not sharp, and the body reads as a rounded loaf rather than a pear or a ridge. Then check, in order: eyes and nose clear, teeth meeting squarely, ears clean, coat free of scabs and bald patches, feet with no redness or swelling on the soles, rear end clean and dry, and a run of both hands over the body and belly feeling for lumps. Boars over two get the rectal pouch check from page 16. Five minutes, once a week, catches most of section three early.

Setup checklist & targets

Print this one. Audit an existing setup against it, or buy against it.

Housing

- ☐ 7.5 sq ft (0.7 m²) for one pig; 10.5 sq ft (1 m²) for a bonded pair
- ☐ Solid floor, no wire or mesh anywhere underfoot
- ☐ Single level. No ramps, no upper shelf counted as floor space
- ☐ Sides at least 12 in (30 cm), open top, good ventilation
- ☐ Paper or fleece bedding. No cedar, no raw pine, no sawdust
- ☐ One hide per pig plus one spare, each with two openings
- ☐ In a room the household uses, out of sun and off drafts
- ☐ Thermometer and hygrometer next to the cage

Food and water

- ☐ Unlimited grass hay, 70 to 80% of the diet, never allowed to run out
- ☐ Hay scattered in two or three places, plus a rack
- ☐ Timothy-based guinea pig pellets, 1 to 2 teaspoons per pig per day
- ☐ Pellet bag within 90 days of its manufacture date
- ☐ 1 to 2 cups of fresh produce per pig per day, rotated
- ☐ Bell pepper daily, roughly a quarter of a medium one per pig
- ☐ Water bottle and bowl both offered, both washed weekly
- ☐ Nothing added to the water, ever

Company and equipment

- ☐ Two guinea pigs, sexed by you or by a vet
- ☐ Two of everything: hides, water sources, hay piles, dishes
- ☐ Daily supervised floor time in a proofed area
- ☐ Digital gram scale, nail clippers, styptic powder
- ☐ Travel carrier, and a syringe plus recovery formula in the cupboard
- ☐ Cavy-savvy exotics vet found, number on page 30

Targets at a glance

Room temperature	65 to 79°F (18 to 26°C), 30 to 60% humidity. Never above 80°F (27°C)
Vitamin C	10 to 25 mg per kg daily; 30 mg/kg or more if growing, pregnant, nursing or ill
Weight	Boars 900 to 1,200 g, sows 700 to 900 g. Weighed weekly, tracked against baseline
Nails	Trimmed every 3 to 4 weeks
Not eating	Call the vet at 8 to 12 hours
Vet	An exam within the first two weeks, then a wellness check every year

Emergency & quick targets card

Fill this in today. Cut it out or photograph it and keep it on your phone.

Cavy-savvy exotics vet _____

Phone _____ Hours _____

After-hours / emergency clinic _____

Phone _____ Drive time _____

Backup carer _____ Phone _____

Pig 1 name _____ Sex _____ Baseline (g) _____

Pig 2 name _____ Sex _____ Baseline (g) _____

Go now, do not wait

- Not eating, or no droppings, for 8 to 12 hours
- Open-mouth breathing, clicking or wheezing
- Hunched posture with teeth grinding
- Bloated or firm abdomen
- Straining to urinate, producing nothing
- Lying flat and panting on a warm day
- A pregnant sow that has gone off her food
- Blood anywhere, or a seizure-like scratching fit

SAY THIS AT THE CLINIC

"This is a guinea pig. Please check any antibiotic against the list of drugs that cause enterotoxemia in this species. Please do not fast her for more than 1 to 2 hours before anesthesia, and if she has not eaten within 2 to 3 hours after, please review her pain relief." Pages 26 and 27 are the ones to hand over. Take the cage mate with you if you can.

Targets, restated

Floor space	7.5 sq ft one pig, 10.5 sq ft a pair, plus 2 to 4 sq ft per extra animal
Room temperature	65 to 79°F (18 to 26°C). Never above 80°F (27°C)
Diet	70 to 80% grass hay, 1 to 2 cups produce per pig, 1 to 2 tsp pellets per pig
Vitamin C	10 to 25 mg/kg daily. A quarter of a red bell pepper per pig covers most of it
Weight	Boars 900 to 1,200 g, sows 700 to 900 g. Act on 5% off baseline
Body temperature	99 to 101.5°F (37.2 to 38.6°C)
Quarantine, new pig	2 to 3 weeks, separate room

Last wellness exam _____ Next due _____

Pellet bag manufacture date _____ Replace by _____

Budget & shopping list

Costed for a pair, because a pair is how this species is kept. US retail, September 2026.

One-time setup

ITEM	LOW	CONSIDERED
Enclosure, 10.5 sq ft or larger (C&C or large habitat)	\$100	\$180
Three hides, two openings each	\$25	\$50
Hay rack or large hay box	\$10	\$25
Two ceramic food dishes, plus a water bottle and a bowl	\$20	\$40
Chew items and a foraging feeder	\$20	\$40
Digital thermometer and hygrometer	\$12	\$25
Nail clippers with styptic powder, and a digital gram scale	\$22	\$43
Travel carrier	\$20	\$45
First bedding, or a set of fleece liners	\$15	\$30
First hay	\$20	\$35
Equipment subtotal	\$264	\$513
Two guinea pigs, rescue to specialty breed	\$20	\$120
Two first exams with an exotics vet	\$100	\$200
Total to get started	\$384	\$833

Ongoing, per month, for a pair

ITEM	LOW, BUYING IN BULK	RETAIL BOXES
Grass hay	\$25	\$60
Pellets	\$6	\$15
Fresh vegetables	\$20	\$50
Bedding	\$15	\$35
Chews, vitamin C supplement, consumables	\$5	\$12
Monthly subtotal	\$71	\$172
Two annual wellness exams, spread over the year	\$8	\$17
Monthly, all in	\$79	\$189

FIRST YEAR, ROUGHLY \$1,160 TO \$2,730, AND THE FUND THAT IS NOT IN IT

Setup plus the animals plus two first exams plus eleven months of running. The spread is almost entirely hay and bedding, and buying hay by the bale from a feed store rather than in pet shop boxes cuts the largest recurring line by more than half. Separately: a sick visit runs \$100 to \$300 or more and a bladder stone surgery or a dental under anesthesia considerably more, both common enough in this species to plan for. Insurance is limited, so put something aside monthly from the day they arrive.

Where not to save: floor space, hay quality, and the vet. Where you can: hides and chews, which are cardboard and untreated wood, and bedding, if you switch to washable fleece and actually do the laundry.

First 30 days checklist

In order. Week one is mostly leaving them alone and watching what goes in and out.

Before they arrive

- ☐ Enclosure built, sited, bedded, and furnished with two hides plus a spare
- ☐ Hay in, in two or three places, plus a rack
- ☐ Exotics vet found and the number written down
- ☐ Thermometer running for a few days to confirm the room's real range
- ☐ Ask the seller what hay, pellets and vegetables they are on, and buy some
- ☐ Quarantine space ready if you already keep guinea pigs

Days 1 to 7

- ☐ Keep to the food they arrived on. Change nothing this week
- ☐ Talk near the cage and hand-feed a piece of pepper without lifting anyone
- ☐ Count droppings roughly every morning. This is the single most useful thing you can do in week one
- ☐ Weigh on day one and again on day seven. Write both numbers down
- ☐ Confirm the water bottle actually runs by pressing the ball, daily
- ☐ Confirm the sex of each pig yourself. Page 17

Days 8 to 14

- ☐ Health check with the exotics vet, both pigs, whether or not anything looks wrong
- ☐ Ask the vet to show you a nail trim and, for a boar, the rectal pouch check
- ☐ Start short lap sessions on the floor. Page 11
- ☐ Begin transitioning hay or pellets to your chosen brand, mixed in gradually. Page 12

Days 15 to 30

- ☐ Daily vegetables established as a routine, bell pepper included every day
- ☐ First supervised floor time in a proofed room. Page 8
- ☐ Weekly weighing and the hands-on check established. Page 28
- ☐ First full cage strip and clean
- ☐ First nail trim
- ☐ Syringe and recovery formula bought and put in the cupboard

WHAT NORMAL LOOKS LIKE BY DAY 30

Eating hay constantly, wheeking when the fridge opens, popcorning during floor time, chatting to each other, sleeping with eyes open or half open, and coming to the front of the cage rather than bolting for a hide when you walk in. Guinea pigs settle faster than most people expect once they have cover, company and a routine, and slower than expected if any one of the three is missing.

Symptom quick reference

What you see, what it might be, and how fast to move. When in doubt with this species, call.

WHAT YOU SEE	MOST LIKELY CAUSES	ACT
Not eating, or eating much less	Dental disease, GI stasis, pain anywhere, scurvy, stress	8 to 12 hours, then call
No droppings, or very few	GI stasis, obstruction, reduced intake	8 to 12 hours, then call
Bloated, firm abdomen	Bloat, obstruction. Page 19	Now
Hunched, teeth grinding	Pain, from anywhere. Very often gut or bladder	Now
Open-mouth breathing	Respiratory disease. Guinea pigs cannot mouth-breathe by choice	Now
Lying flat, panting, drooling on a warm day	Heat stress. Page 7	Now, cool then vet
Straining to urinate, nothing produced	Blocked bladder. Page 23	Now
Squeaking while urinating, pink staining	Bladder stone, sludge, or cystitis	Same day
Frantic scratching, running, seizure-like fits	Mange mites, far more often than a neurological problem. Page 25	Same day
Wet chin and chest, dropping food	Dental disease. Page 20	Within days
Weight down more than 5% from baseline	Dental disease first, then anything else	Within days
Rough puffed coat, stiffness, reluctance to move	Scurvy. Page 21	Within days
Swollen joints, difficulty picking food up	Scurvy, progressing	Same day
Sneezing repeatedly, nasal or eye discharge	Respiratory infection, dust, ammonia. Page 22	Within days
Symmetrical hair loss down both flanks, skin normal	Ovarian cysts in a sow. Page 24	Within days
Hair loss with scabs, crusting, itching	Mites, lice, ringworm. Ringworm transfers to people	Within days
A lump anywhere, particularly the neck	Lymphadenitis, abscess, cyst, tumor. Page 25	Within days
Red, swollen or ulcerated soles	Bumblefoot. Check the flooring and the weight	Within days
Soft or clumped droppings	Too much fresh food, or a sudden diet change	Pull back a day, then call
True diarrhea, or a wet soiled rear	Infection, diet, or a reaction to an antibiotic. Page 26	Same day
A pregnant sow gone off her food	Pregnancy toxemia. Page 24	Now
Stopped popcorning, stopped talking	Any illness. A change in a habit is a symptom in this species	Within days

Daily, weekly & seasonal routine

Fifteen minutes a day, an hour a week, and one job that changes with the weather.

Every day

- ☐ Fresh water, bottle and bowl. Press the ball to check it runs
- ☐ Hay topped up, scattered, at least twice
- ☐ Measured pellets, 1 to 2 tsp per pig
- ☐ Fresh vegetables, bell pepper among them, taken out after a couple of hours
- ☐ Spot-clean the litter corner and soiled bedding
- ☐ Look at the droppings while you do it
- ☐ Check the room thermometer
- ☐ Floor time, or lap time, and watch each pig move and eat

Every week

- ☐ Weigh every pig and log it. Page 37
- ☐ The five-minute hands-on check. Page 28
- ☐ Full bedding change, or fleece washed and swapped
- ☐ Wash water bottle, bowl and dishes properly
- ☐ Brush long or rosetted coats. Page 16
- ☐ Rotate a chew or move a hide to somewhere new

Every month

- ☐ Full cage strip and wash, with the pigs safely in a pen
- ☐ Nail trim, roughly every 3 to 4 weeks
- ☐ Restock hay and pellets, checking the pellet manufacture date rather than the sell-by
- ☐ Read the weight log as a trend rather than as this week's number
- ☐ Rectal pouch check on any boar over about two years old. Page 16

Seasonal

WHEN	WHAT CHANGES
Spring	Fresh grass appears. Introduce it slowly over a week or two, hand-picked from untreated ground, never mower clippings. Page 14
Summer	The dangerous season. Check the room's afternoon temperature rather than its morning one, close curtains early, put tiles and wrapped frozen bottles in the cage, and never leave pigs in a conservatory, a car or a shed. Page 7
Fall	Hay quality changes with each new cut, so a pig that suddenly refuses hay may be reacting to a new batch rather than being ill. Buy the year's bulk hay now if you are going to
Winter	Heating dries the air, and drafts multiply. Keep the cage off cold walls and away from doors, add extra hay for bedding warmth, and watch for the first sneeze. Page 22
Yearly	Wellness exam for each pig, with the teeth specifically checked. Replace worn hides and chewed dishes. Re-read the emergency card and confirm the out-of-hours arrangement still stands

Heat waves, power outages & travel

For this species the emergency that matters is heat, and the rule in an outage is keep feeding.

A heat wave, with or without power

Losing air conditioning in hot weather is the genuine emergency for a guinea pig, far more than losing heating in cold weather. Work down this list in order.

1. **Move them to the coolest room in the house**, usually a ground-floor room on the shaded side. A basement is often the best place in the building.
2. **Close curtains and blinds early**, before the sun reaches that side, not after the room is already hot.
3. **Ceramic or stone tiles in the cage**. Keep spares in the fridge and rotate them.
4. **Wrapped frozen bottles**, positioned so the pigs can lie against them or move away.
5. **Damp towel over part of the cage** with air moving past it, never sealing the cage in.
6. **Extra water in more than one container**, and water-rich foods: cucumber, romaine, melon and apple.
7. **If a pig shows heat stress**, damp the fur with cool, not iced, water and go to the vet. Page 7.

IN A POWER CUT, KEEP FEEDING

A guinea pig's danger in an outage is not cold, it is a gut that stops moving. Hay, pellets and vegetables all continue exactly as normal, and water is offered more often rather than less. This is the opposite of the advice for a reptile, where temperature comes first, and it is the single most important sentence on this page. Extra hay to burrow into is how a guinea pig keeps warm; a heat pad in the cage is a chew hazard and a burn risk.

Travel

SITUATION	WHAT TO DO
Vet trip	Solid carrier lined with a towel over bedding, hay inside, a piece of cucumber or pepper for moisture rather than a water bottle that will spill. Drape a towel over most of it: a prey animal wants somewhere to hide, not a view of the waiting room. Take the cage mate. Page 27
A long drive	Carrier belted in with its side facing the direction of travel, so a hard stop does not throw them face first into the end. Out of direct sun, air conditioning on but not blowing at the carrier. Stop every couple of hours to offer water and check them. Hay for the whole journey
Moving house	They travel with you, not in the van. Set the cage up in a quiet room first, keep the same bedding smell if you can by carrying one unwashed fleece across, and expect a week of settling
Holidays	Guinea pigs are not left alone overnight. Water fowls, a bottle blocks, a pig stops eating and nobody sees. Use the sitter sheet on page 36
Outdoors in summer	A run on the grass is excellent, in shade, supervised, never on treated ground, never in the middle of the day, and never left unattended with a predator or a hot spell possible

NEVER LEAVE A GUINEA PIG IN A PARKED CAR

Not for five minutes, not with the windows cracked. A car interior reaches lethal temperatures for this species faster than for a dog, and heat is the thing this animal is least able to survive.

Pet-sitter sheet

Fill it in and leave it on the fridge. Assume the sitter has never kept a guinea pig.

Pig 1 _____	Pig 2 _____
Owner _____	Phone _____
Exotics vet _____	Phone _____
Emergency clinic _____	Phone _____
Backup contact _____	Phone _____
Medications _____	

Every day, please

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ Fresh water. Press the ball on the bottle to check it actually runs | ☐ Fresh vegetables, including a piece of bell pepper for each pig |
| ☐ Hay topped up morning and evening. It must never run out | ☐ Take out anything uneaten after a couple of hours |
| ☐ Pellets, one to two teaspoons each, no more | ☐ Clear the dirty corner and glance at the droppings |

THE TWO THINGS THAT MATTER MOST

1. Check the room temperature every visit. Above 80°F (27°C) these animals are in danger. Close the curtains, put the wrapped frozen bottles from the freezer in the cage, and call us.

2. Check that both pigs are eating. A guinea pig that has not eaten and has not left droppings for 8 to 12 hours needs a vet, not a note left for our return. This is not an animal you can wait on overnight.

Never feed

Avocado, onion, garlic, chives, leeks, rhubarb, chocolate, mushrooms, raw potato, unripe tomato, fruit pits or seeds, meat, eggs, dairy, iceberg lettuce, bread, pasta, cereal, nuts or seeds. Nothing from a packet unless it is in the cupboard we showed you.

Call us if you see

- | | |
|---|---|
| • Either pig not eating, or hay untouched | • Sitting hunched and still, not moving to food |
| • No droppings, or very few | • Blood anywhere, or squeaking while urinating |
| • Lying flat and panting, or breathing with an open mouth | • Anything that just seems different from yesterday |

Where the hay and pellets are _____

Where the bedding and cleaning things are _____

Anything else _____

Owner log

Same day each week, same time, before the morning vegetables. Write the number even when nothing has changed, because the unremarkable weeks are what make one remarkable week readable. Act on a fall of about 5% off a pig's own baseline, or on three weeks of decline however small each step is. Bring this page to every vet appointment.

Equipment & vet log

What was replaced, what was treated, and what is due next.

Consumables & equipment

ITEM	DATE	NEXT DUE	NOTES
Pellet bag opened (manufacture date)			
Hay restocked			
Nails trimmed			
Full cage strip			

Veterinary

DATE	WHICH PIG	REASON	WEIGHT (G)	FINDINGS, DRUGS GIVEN, FOLLOW-UP

Record the name of every drug given, not just "antibiotics". Page 26 is why.

Twelve-month planner

MONTH	WEIGHED	NAILS	WELLNESS EXAM	NOTES
	☐	☐	☐	
	☐	☐	☐	
	☐	☐	☐	
	☐	☐	☐	
	☐	☐	☐	
	☐	☐	☐	
	☐	☐	☐	
	☐	☐	☐	
	☐	☐	☐	
	☐	☐	☐	
	☐	☐	☐	
	☐	☐	☐	

REFERENCE

Glossary

Terms used earlier in this book, in the sense they were used.

Boar	A male guinea pig
Bumblefoot	Pododermatitis. Inflammation and ulceration of the soles, from wire floors, damp bedding, obesity or hard surfaces
C&C cage	Cubes and Coroplast. An enclosure built from wire storage cubes and corrugated plastic, the standard way to get real floor area affordably
Cavy	The correct name for the animal, and the reason a guinea-pig-experienced vet is called cavy-savvy
Cecotrope	A softer, nutrient-rich dropping produced by the caecum and eaten directly from the vent. Normal and necessary
Enterotoxemia	Overgrowth of toxin-producing gut bacteria, often after the wrong antibiotic. Page 26
GI stasis	The gut slowing or stopping. The most common emergency in this species
Grease gland	A gland at the base of the spine, more active in boars, that gets waxy and matted
Hindgut fermenter	An animal that digests fiber by bacterial fermentation in the caecum and large intestine. Why fiber and antibiotic choice both matter so much
Malocclusion	Teeth that no longer meet correctly and therefore no longer wear correctly
Neophobia	Refusal of unfamiliar food. Pronounced in this species, and a reason to change diets gradually
Obligate nasal breather	An animal that cannot switch to breathing through its mouth. An open-mouthed guinea pig is an emergency
Ovarian cyst	The most common reproductive disorder in sows. Classic sign is symmetrical flank hair loss
Popcorning	A sudden vertical jump with a twist. Play, and a sign of a comfortable animal
Pubic symphysis	The cartilage joint at the front of the pelvis. It fuses in a sow who has never given birth, which is why a first litter after about 6 to 9 months is dangerous
Rectal pouch	A pocket behind the anus in boars, which becomes impacted in older intact males. Page 16
Rumblestrutting	A low vibrating call with a swaying walk. Dominance or courtship, and normal during introductions
Scurvy	Vitamin C deficiency. Collagen production fails, so joints, gums, vessels and healing all break down
Sow	A female guinea pig
Trixacarus caviae	The burrowing mange mite of guinea pigs. Causes itching severe enough to look like a seizure
Urolithiasis	Urinary stones, typically calcium carbonate in this species
Wheek	The loud rising food call. A learned behavior aimed at people, not an instinct

REFERENCE

Sources & further reading

Where the numbers in this book came from.

Veterinary and welfare sources

SOURCE	WHAT IT SUPPLIED
LafeberVet, <i>Basic Information Sheet: Guinea Pig</i>	Life span, adult weights by sex, body temperature, heart and respiratory rates, sexual maturity, gestation, litter size, weaning, and the pubic symphysis note
Merck / MSD Veterinary Manual, <i>Housing and Nutrition of Guinea Pigs</i>	The 7.5 sq ft minimum with 2 to 4 sq ft per additional animal, solid flooring, bedding to use and avoid, the 65 to 79°F and 30 to 60% humidity range, hay, pellet and produce amounts, vitamin C by body weight, and both reasons not to supplement through the water
Merck / MSD, <i>Noninfectious Diseases of Guinea Pigs</i>	Hypovitaminosis C signs and treatment, dental disease and the 4 to 6 week recurrence interval, urolithiasis and stone composition, ovarian cysts, and pododermatitis
Merck / MSD, <i>Infectious Diseases of Guinea Pigs and Common Health Problems</i>	Pneumonia as a leading cause of death with <i>Bordetella</i> and <i>Streptococcus</i> , cervical lymphadenitis, <i>Trixacarus caviae</i> with its dosing, lice, and zoonotic dermatophytosis
Merck / MSD, <i>Anatomy, Physiology and Behavior of Guinea Pigs</i>	The rectal pouch and its impaction in older intact boars
VCA Animal Hospitals, <i>Guinea Pigs: Feeding</i>	The 10 to 50 mg daily vitamin C figure, the high-vitamin-C vegetable list, unlimited low-calcium hay, and the foods to avoid
Merck / MSD, <i>Clinical Techniques for Guinea Pigs</i>	The drug classes that carry the enterotoxemia risk, the antimicrobials that can generally be used instead, and the 1 to 2 hour pre-anesthetic fast and its reason
Merck / MSD, <i>Lincosamides Use in Animals</i> ; Merck / MSD, <i>Management of Rabbits</i>	Clindamycin and lincomycin named as contraindicated in guinea pigs, and the 2 to 3 hour post-operative eating bar
VCA Animal Hospitals, <i>Health Problems in Rodents</i>	The never-give antibiotic list by any route, the 80°F (27°C) enclosure ceiling, and the heat stroke sign order
University of Missouri College of Veterinary Medicine, <i>Antibiotic-Induced Enterotoxemia in Guinea Pigs</i>	The two <i>Clostridioides difficile</i> toxins, and death 1 to 2 days after the onset of diarrhea
RSPCA Knowledgebase, <i>Will My Guinea Pigs Be Affected by Heat?</i>	Heat stress from 24°C and most commonly above 28°C, the 18 to 23°C comfortable band, the sign order, and treatment as oxygen and intravenous fluids while cooling
PDSA, keeping guinea pigs cool; Blue Cross, guinea pigs in summer	Cold water causing shock and ice causing burns on thin skin, and the stretched-out posture with the back feet trailing as a too-warm signal
Lafeber Co., <i>Tips for Grooming Your Guinea Pig</i> ; LafeberVet, <i>Clinical Approach to the Guinea Pig</i>	The 6 to 8 week nail interval, the torch-behind-a-dark-nail method, short coats brushed every few days, the grease gland swab, and the bonded cage mate at the clinic
PetMD, <i>Vitamin C Deficiency in Guinea Pigs</i>	Signs appearing within 2 to 3 weeks of an insufficient diet, and per-kilogram vitamin C figures agreeing with Merck's
PetMD, <i>GI Stasis in Guinea Pigs</i> ; Oxbow Animal Health, <i>Guinea Pig Care Guide</i>	The 8 to 12 hour threshold, the 24 to 48 hour deterioration window, and the 24 to 72 hour recovery figure
Published work on guinea pig welfare and husbandry	The link between secure hiding options and reduced stress indicators, and the up-to-80% of the day spent foraging

REFERENCE

Version history & about

What changed, and when, so you can tell which edition you are holding.

VERSION	DATE	TEMPLATE	WHAT CHANGED
1.0	Aug 2026	pre-t3	First edition, 22 pages on the earlier layout
2.0	Sep 2026	t3	Full rebuild on the current template at 39 pages. New pages for heat stress, pairing and bonding, sounds and body language, hay, vegetables, grooming and boar cleaning, sexing and the breeding deadline, and eight further health pages including the antibiotic page. Vitamin C restated by body weight rather than as a flat figure. Budget itemized for a pair so the lines sum
2.1	Sep 2026	t3	Corrections edition from a cross-check against the small mammal articles published in September 2026. The heat danger line moves from 82°F to VCA's 80°F (27°C) on all five pages that carry it, with the RSPCA's 75°F onset and 82°F most-common figures named alongside; Merck's 65 to 79°F comfortable range is unchanged. The heat stress sign order is rebuilt around the RSPCA and VCA lists, with the stretched-out posture credited to Blue Cross as a too-warm signal rather than as the head of a clinical sequence. Cold water is explained as a shock and ice-burn risk rather than as vasoconstriction. The antibiotic page is rewritten by drug class, gains amoxicillin, amoxicillin-clavulanate and cephalosporins, loses chlortetracycline and spiramycin, and gains the drugs a vet can usually use instead and the 1 to 2 day onset. Fasting gains Merck's 1 to 2 hour figure and the 2 to 3 hour post-operative eating bar. Nail trims move to Lafeber's 6 to 8 weeks and short coats to every few days. Sources and version history split onto two pages

Beastly Facts guides drawn on: guinea pig tank setup, feeding, scurvy and vitamin C, health issues, handling, enrichment, and cost, plus the small mammal guides on temperature and heat stress, grooming and nails, vet visits and travel, and antibiotic-associated enterotoxemia. Where they disagreed with a veterinary source, the veterinary source is what is printed here.

Beastly Facts publishes fact-checked care references for keepers who would rather read one accurate thing than ten contradictory ones. This is a husbandry reference, not veterinary advice.

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